# STEP 1: CAREER & INCOME

Choose a career and calculate your monthly take-home pay.

MISSION #1

**My name** _____ **Date** _____

## 1 Pick a real career

Rounded-down 2025 U.S. median pay; Skilled Trades is an estimate. Not starting or apprentice pay.



**Graphic designer**
**$30** / hour
**Typical qualification** Bachelor's degree



**Veterinary technician**
**$22** / hour
**Typical qualification** Associate degree + state credential



**Software developer**
**$65** / hour
**Typical qualification** Bachelor's degree



**Skilled trades**
**$30** / hour
**Typical qualification** Trade-school path + hands-on training



**Office assistant**
**$21** / hour
**Entry path** No degree or trade certificate; employer training



**Restaurant team member**
**$15** / hour
**Entry path** No degree or trade certificate; employer training



**Retail sales associate**
**$17** / hour
**Entry path** No degree or trade certificate; employer training

## 2 Find your monthly income

**Work rule:** 40 hours/week. Budget from two biweekly paychecks. Round down to whole dollars.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Weekly Gross Pay | × 40 = | |
| 2. Biweekly Gross Paycheck<br>Two weeks of pay, before taxes | × 2 = | |
| 3. Estimated Monthly Gross Pay<br>Two biweekly paychecks, before taxes | × 2 = | |
| 4. Estimated Monthly Taxes<br>Use a flat 20% classroom estimate for every career. | × **20%** = | |

Biweekly pay usually means 26 checks per year. Some months have a third check; this two-check budget is not the annual monthly average.

### Monthly take-home pay

Monthly gross – estimated taxes = take-home pay.

_____ – _____ = _____

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

**What is your gross pay for a whole year?**

Biweekly gross paycheck × 26 paychecks.

_____

# STEP 2: HOUSING & TRANSPORTATION

Compare homes, utility bills, and monthly transportation costs.

MISSION #2

A **need** helps you live and stay well, like food and a safe home. Choose housing and travel for yourself. The shared-home option includes one roommate. All costs below are monthly.

## 1 Choose your home

Raleigh rental scenarios—not mortgages or measured averages by home type.



**Cozy apartment**
1 bedroom · 750 sq ft



**Townhouse**
2 bedrooms · 1,200 sq ft



**House**
3 bedrooms · 1,800 sq ft



**Shared home / rent a room**
Private room · 1 roommate
Your half of rent & utilities

224

### Estimated rent and utility bills · per month

| Monthly bill | Apartment | Townhouse | House | Shared home<br>Your share |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Rent only** | **$1,300** | **$1,900** | **$2,300** | **$950** |
| **Electricity**<br>Includes heating & cooling | $105 | $150 | $210 | $75 |
| **Water & sewer** | $60 | $75 | $80 | $37 |
| **Trash** | $20 | $25 | $30 | $12 |
| **Trash** | $20 | $25 | $30 | |
| **Utilities only**<br>Rent is NOT included | **$185** | **$250** | **$320** | **$124** |
| **Utilities only**<br>Rent is NOT included | **$185** | **$250** | **$320** | |

## 2 Choose how to travel

Choose one transportation plan for your monthly budget.

**Walk or bike**
**$20** / month

**Public Transit**
**$80** / month

**Car**
**$780** / month

### Transport bills · per month

N/A = no bill for this option. Costs & assumptions

| Monthly bill | Walk / bike | Public Transit | Car |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Car payment** | N/A | N/A | $350 |
| **Gas / fuel** | N/A | N/A | $150 |
| **Vehicle insurance** | N/A | N/A | $160 |
| **Public Transit pass** | N/A | $80 | N/A |
| **Maintenance & repairs**<br>Monthly upkeep set-aside | $20 | N/A | $100 |
| **Registration & vehicle taxes**<br>Annual costs set aside monthly | N/A | N/A | $20 |
| **Total monthly transport** | **$20** | **$80** | **$780** |

## STEP 2: HOUSING & TRAVEL TOTALS

Record your selected home and transportation costs.

MISSION #2

Use your selected home and travel plan from the previous page. Add rent, utilities, transportation, and renters insurance. Daily living bills are on Step 3.

| | |
|---|---|
| Rent only | _____ |
| Utilities only | _____ |
| Renters insurance | $20 |
| **Housing Subtotal** | _____ |
| **Transportation Subtotal** | _____ |

**Why did you choose this home or way to travel?**

# STEP 3: LIFESTYLE & SAVINGS

Plan daily living expenses, lifestyle bills, and monthly savings.

MISSION #3

Budget for one adult in Raleigh, NC. Living bills and savings are monthly; fun money is weekly. These costs are separate from Step 2 housing and transportation.

## 🛒 Daily Living & Lifestyle Bills

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | 🛒 Groceries & food | $400 |
| ☐ | 🌐 Home internet / Wi-Fi | $70 |
| ☐ | 📱 Mobile phone plan | $55 |
| ☐ | 🩺 Health insurance & medical care | $280 |
| ☐ | 👕 Clothing, toiletries & household supplies | $150 |
| ☐ | 🎬 Streaming services & gaming | $30 |
| | **Monthly living-bills subtotal** | _____ |

## 💰 Pay Yourself First: Savings

**Savings goal**

_____

**Monthly savings amount**

$ _____

## 🍽️ Choose Your Weekly Fun Money

Choose up to 4 weekly allowances. None is okay. Subscriptions are separate.

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ | 🌳 Parks & free events | $0 / week | ☐ | ☕ Coffee & café snacks | $10 / week |
| ☐ | 🥪 Lunch out | $12 / week | ☐ | 🍽️ Dinner out | $25 / week |
| ☐ | 🎟️ Movie theater visits | $15 / week | ☐ | 🍦 Ice cream & desserts | $8 / week |
| ☐ | 📚 Books & magazines | $10 / week | ☐ | 🎨 Art & craft supplies | $12 / week |
| ☐ | 🎮 Game purchases (not subscriptions) | $10 / week | ☐ | 🏀 Sports & recreation | $15 / week |
| ☐ | 🎵 Concerts & events fund | $20 / week | ☐ | 🏛️ Museums & attractions | $12 / week |
| | **Weekly fun-money subtotal** | | | | _____ |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Monthly fun-money allowance<br>Weekly subtotal × 4 for this two-paycheck budget | _____ × 4 = | _____ |
| Monthly savings | | _____ |
| **Total lifestyle & savings**<br>Monthly living bills + monthly fun money + savings | | _____ |

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

**If you save the same amount for 3 months, how much will you have?**

_____

# STEP 4: BUDGET CHECK & REFLECTION

Compare your monthly income with expenses and savings.

FINAL STEP

Review your monthly cash flow. Transfer the subtotals from Steps 2 and 3, then compare total expenses and savings with your monthly take-home income.

## Budget Summary Table

| Category Description | Monthly Total ($) |
|---|---|
| **TOTAL MONTHLY INCOME (A)**<br>Take-home pay after estimated taxes | _____ |
| Housing Subtotal<br>Rent + utilities + renters insurance | _____ |
| Transportation Subtotal<br>Selected travel plan, including all applicable costs | _____ |
| Lifestyle & Savings Subtotal<br>Daily living bills + monthly fun money + monthly savings | _____ |
| **TOTAL MONTHLY EXPENSES (B)**<br>Housing + transportation + lifestyle & savings | _____ |

This cash-flow budget includes savings in (B) because that money is set aside. Savings remains your money—it is not a purchase. Taxes have already been deducted from (A); do not count them again.

Monthly income (A) – monthly expenses (B)

**Net Remaining Cash** _____

A negative balance is a deficit; zero is balanced; a positive balance is a surplus.

1. **Is your monthly budget balanced, in surplus, or in deficit? What adjustment would you make?**

2. **Which category—housing, transportation, or lifestyle and savings—has the largest subtotal?**

3. **An unexpected repair costs $150. Can your net remaining cash cover it? If not, how would you fund the repair?**

**SAVINGS RATE**

**Calculate the percentage of monthly income allocated to savings.**

(Monthly savings ÷ monthly income A) × 100. Use a calculator if needed.

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